Chapter 1 – The Indus River Valley

It is easy to look at a modern political map and recognize the country that inhabits the immense subcontinent of southern Asia. Most of its borders are defined by warm oceans; the northeast delineated by the towering Himalayan mountains. Yet, at the northwestern edge of modern India, a crucial piece has been removed: that of the Indus River Valley, which lies in today's Pakistan. Despite the political separation, it was from this fertile section of the subcontinent that Indian civilization once sprang.

Just as the Euphrates and Tigris Rivers became the cradle of civilization to the ancient people of Mesopotamia (modern Iraq), the Indus River Valley and the Sarasvati River provided the resources and safety early south Asian people needed to build cities and consolidate their wealth. As early as 3000 BCE, the river valley flourished with tall buildings, agriculture, and trade that stretched from modern Afghanistan into northern India. As many as six million people may have lived here during the peak of the Indus-Sarasvati civilization, around 4,000 years ago.

The most important feature of the Indus Valley was—and still is—the river that stretches southwest across the entirety of Pakistan until meeting the Arabian Sea. It was an alluring stretch of fertile, water-adjacent land for nomads and immigrants even thousands of years before large cities appeared. The influx of ideas helped solidify the valley's future as a permanent settlement, while its inhabitants learned to cultivate sesame, rice, peas, dates, and sugarcane. They used cotton and hemp for textiles and created fire-baked clay bricks for buildings.

Thanks to a love of archaeological pursuit that became highly fashionable during the reign of England's Queen Victoria, multiple sites were discovered and cataloged along the Indus River by Indian and British treasure hunters. The first archaeological proof of the powerful and ancient Indian culture came from Harappa, thus causing the civilization and culture of these early people to often be referred to as Harappan. The ruins of the city, first rediscovered in 1826, are located in the Sahiwal District of Pakistan, near the border of India. Discovery of Harappa by those researchers challenged the belief of most Western historians and